

MIDDLE SCHOOL HACKS



Every ministry is different. Whether you're teaching middle schoolers, high schoolers, teenagers with disabilities, or all three, here's how to hack this series to fit your unique and diverse audience.

REMEMBER

Middle schoolers have limited control over their friendships, as these often form naturally based on proximity—like classmates, teammates, and neighbors. Despite having less autonomy, they can still make choices that matter within the friendships they do have. Help them identify things like, which friendships to invest more deeply in, setting healthy boundaries, or choosing how to respond when friendships change.

REVISE

To make this series more accessible for middle schoolers, here's what to adjust...

- **In Week 1's "Friendship Tug-of-War (Part 1)," use three ropes labeled "fun," "peer pressure," and "kindness" instead of five.** This keeps the visual simple and helps middle schoolers better grasp how influence works in real life.
- **In Week 2's "Mad Libs Theater: Bad Advice Edition" activity, prep students with sample bad advice like, "Spend all your money on candy."** This adds humor while modeling the concept for students who struggle with abstract scenarios.
- **For the "Growing Good" reflection in week 3, replace the selfie camera step with small mirrors or have students draw a quick self-portrait instead.** Not all middle schoolers have phones, and offering a physical or creative alternative keeps the reflection personal and inclusive.

REPLACE

And here are the Building Blocks you may want to swap for something else...

- **Throughout the month, for some of the modules where a leader shares a personal story, replace it with a "Choose Your Own Adventure" storytelling game using a fictional scenario tied to the lesson.** Middle schoolers stay more engaged when they get to interact or vote on a story outcome. It also gives them freedom to explore choices and consequences without the pressure of someone else's personal experience shaping the "right" answer.